



QUICKSTART

IDLE — Beginner Setup & Quickstart Guide

A compact, step-by-step guide to get you coding with **IDLE**, Python's simple Integrated Development and Learning Environment — works on Windows, macOS, and Linux.

Beginner **IDLE** **Python 3** **Shell**

Why IDLE?

Comes with Python (no extra install needed).

Simple and distraction-free — great for learning basics.

Interactive Shell + script editor + debugger in one small package.

1) Check if Python (and IDLE) is already installed

Open a terminal / command prompt and run:

Windows (cmd or PowerShell)

```
python --version
# or
py --version
```

macOS / Linux

```
python3 --version
```

If you see `Python 3.x.x`, Python is installed and IDLE is included. If not, continue to step 2.

2) Install Python (if needed)

Recommended source: the official installer at **python.org/downloads** (pick the latest Python 3 release).

Windows

Run the installer (.exe).

Important: check *Add Python 3.x to PATH* and choose *Install Now*.

macOS

Download the macOS installer (.pkg) and run it. Or use `brew install python` if you use Homebrew.

Linux (Debian/Ubuntu)

Run:

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install python3
```



3) Launch IDLE

Windows: Start Menu → *IDLE (Python 3.x)*

macOS: Finder → Applications → Python 3.x → *IDLE.app* or in Terminal:

```
python3 -m idlelib
# or
python3 -m idlelib.idle
```

Linux: try `idle3` or:

```
python3 -m idlelib
```

You should see the Python Shell window (interactive prompt `>>>`).

4) Quick tour — Python Shell (interactive)

The Shell is for testing small pieces of code quickly. Try:

```
>>> 2 + 2
4
>>> print('Hello from IDLE')
Hello from IDLE
>>> 'abc'.upper()
'ABC'
```

Use the Shell for quick experiments and learning how things work.

5) Write and run your first script (recommended)

File → New File (or press **Ctrl+N** / **⌘N**).

Type this example program and save as `hello.py`:

```
# hello.py
def main():
    name = input('What is your name? ')
    print(f'Hello, {name}!')

if __name__ == '__main__':
    main()
```

Then Run → Run Module (or press **F5**). If not saved, IDLE will prompt you to save first.

6) Debugging basics in IDLE

- Debug → **Debugger** to open a small stepping debugger.
- Insert `breakpoint()` in your code to pause execution.

- Use `import pdb; pdb.set_trace()` for the pdb debugger.

IDLE's debugger is simple and great for learning; for heavier debugging later, consider VS Code or PyCharm.

7) Configure IDLE to feel comfortable

Options → Configure IDLE has helpful tabs:

- **Fonts/Tabs:** set font size and *Indent width = 4*.
- **Highlights:** choose a theme (light/dark)
- **General / Keys:** tweak behavior and shortcuts

Good defaults: 12–14pt font, spaces (not tabs), indent width 4.

8) Install packages & virtual environments (recommended workflow)

Install packages with pip (ensure you use the same python interpreter):

```
python -m pip install requests
# or
python3 -m pip install requests
```

Create & activate a venv:

```
python -m venv env
# Windows
env\Scripts\activate
# macOS / Linux
source env/bin/activate
```

To run IDLE inside the venv (so it uses that environment):

```
python -m idlelib
# or
python -m idlelib.idle
```

9) Best practices & tips

- Save often. IDLE won't run unsaved files.
- Use `if __name__ == '__main__':` for script entry.
- Keep functions short and test them in the Shell.
- Add comments and meaningful variable names.
- Learn PEP 8 basics (4-space indent, snake_case).

10) Common troubleshooting

- **"python is not recognized" (Windows)** — reinstall Python and check *Add Python to PATH* or use the `py` launcher.
- **IDLE not launching** — run `python -m idlelib` in terminal and inspect errors.
- **Packages not found in IDLE** — ensure packages installed in the same interpreter (use `python -m pip`).
- **F5 doesn't run** — save the file first.

Cheat sheet (useful shortcuts)

New file: **Ctrl+N** /  **N**

Open: **Ctrl+O** /  **O**

Save: **Ctrl+S** /  **S**

Run module: **F5**

Interrupt: Shell → Interrupt
Execution

Configure: Options →
Configure IDLE

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Quick tips

- If IDLE seems slow on older PCs, try VS Code with the Python extension later.
- Use virtual environments for each project to avoid dependency conflicts.
- Explore interactive Python tutorials to practice small tasks.